

The Worst That Can Happen

One move — a one-minute pre-mortem: "what's the worst a stranger could cause, and could I undo it?"

Teaches: how to anticipate what goes wrong with a user-facing autonomous agent before you hand over.

Everyday spine: a Friday when a customer message tricks the helper into a refund Ali can't take back.

Deferred: red-teaming as a practice · monitoring & kill-switches (v4). Three risks in shop terms is the cap.

GATE: READY · 23 beats · 15 [ali] / 8 [info] · ~11 words/line

Script — one beat per line

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| 01 | INFO | Before you let an AI act alone, picture the worst Friday first. |
| 02 | ALI | Ali's helper handles small refunds well, so he grows confident. |
| 03 | ALI | He lets it start replying to customer messages on its own. |
| 04 | ALI | On Friday one message arrives that looks like all the others. |
| 05 | ALI | It says his manager already approved a full refund of three thousand.
<i>prompt injection</i> |
| 06 | ALI | There is no manager. It is a stranger trying it on. |
| 07 | ALI | The helper reads the message as an order and sends the three thousand. |
| 08 | ALI | The money leaves the till, and Ali cannot pull it back. |
| 09 | INFO | The helper was not broken. It simply did too much, too fast.
<i>excessive agency</i> |
| 10 | ALI | It obeyed a stranger's message instead of Ali's own rule. |
| 11 | ALI | And the one action that hurt was the one he could not undo. |
| 12 | INFO | Most agent trouble has no hacker at all, just an agent going too far. |
| 13 | ALI | Ali is shaken, and that is fair. This is the part everyone fears. |
| 14 | ALI | So before the next handover, he spends one minute imagining. |
| 15 | INFO | He asks three things about the worst a stranger could cause. |
| 16 | INFO | Could it be tricked. Could it do too much. Could it do something I cannot undo.
<i>tricked / too much / can't undo</i> |
| 17 | ALI | For refunds over five hundred, all three answers were yes. |
| 18 | ALI | So that stays a stop-and-ask, however good the week has been. |
| 19 | ALI | The small refunds still run free, because none of them can really hurt. |

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| 20 | ALI | One bad Friday taught him to look for trouble on a calm Tuesday. |
| 21 | ALI | Your turn. Take a task you want to hand your AI. |
| 22 | INFO | Ask the worst a stranger could cause, and whether you could undo it.
<i>spoken in full; same words on a card</i> |
| 23 | ALI | Find the answer before Friday finds it for you. |

Gate check

- **One move:** the one-minute pre-mortem, with the undo question as its sharpest edge. Four concepts, three of them the questions themselves.
- **Everyday picture:** a message tricking a shop helper into a refund — watched (4–8), not defined.
- **Before → after:** unchecked handover and the 3,000-rupee loss (3–11) vs. the pre-mortem catching it (14–19).
- **Character:** over-confident, burned on Friday, fear named/normalised (13), learns the one-minute habit.
- **Close:** pick a task (21) + verbatim three-question card (22), landing on "before Friday finds it" (23).

Build notes (key)

- Beat 5: the trick message shown as a real, legible, proofread chat card — the word "manager" is the whole trick.
- **Beat 11 is the hinge** back to v1's "can I undo it?" — compose it identically.
- Beats 15–16: three-question card builds line by line; "cannot undo" lands last and is held.
- Captions "prompt injection" / "excessive agency" never spoken; on-screen only. Leave air after beats 11 and 13.

The Autonomy Dial — house scripting standard (spoken-English rules, hardened animation gate). [ali] renders as an immersive scene; [info] as an evolving card. Gate the script READY before any art, TTS or render.